The club dance floor is often thought of as egalitarian—an immersive space where the DJ, the music and the energy and euphoria of the dancers are equally important components. The dance floor has also been a historically safe space for marginalised identities and sexualities. But this reputation is increasingly at odds with the realities of commercialised contemporary club culture. In *DJ Mag's* top 100 DJs list for 2022, for example, there were only 13 women. And that's the highest it has ever been. Closer home, at India's premier electronic music festival Sunburn, women make up less than 10 per cent of the lineup most years.

Indian women looking to build a career behind the decks face many challenges, from social censure for participating in a late-night entertainment industry to the lack of public safety for women. Beyond those factors, too, the club scene isn't particularly welcoming to women. "A big problem is that you aren't able to access a lot of the tools and equipment," says Priyamvada Grover, who DJs as Priyum. Grover took up DJing after attending a Women in Electronic Music workshop organised by The Wild City in collaboration with the British Council. She and a few other participants would come together to form an all-women DJ collective, Coven Code. "Most DJs don't get formal schooling; they just learn from each other. But if you're a woman, even asking a guy for access to his studio isn't always safe."

"Promoters can be cliquey, and programming is mostly, not forward-thinking," adds Munbir Chawla, co-founder of The Wild City and the Magnetic Fields music festival. "The focus is on what moves tickets, and nightlife spaces can be intimidating as well." Even with these challenges, the success of DJs like Ma Faiza and Kini Rao has encouraged many women to follow in their footsteps. DJ Ishani Mazumdar, who has been spinning underground hip-hop, soul and funk for over a decade, believes that despite challenges, things are changing.

From social censure to lack of safety, Indian women looking to build a career as DJs face a slew of challenges

"Other women who have been there before me have paved the way for [us]," she says. "There was a time we weren't taken as seriously, but given the years of grinding, [our male colleagues] realise we are here to stay." This shift was helped by what seemed like a real movement for change in the wake of the #MeToo allegations within the industry in 2018. As the nightlife scene's many skeletons tumbled out of the closet, artistes, promoters and venues realised they needed to do more to make their spaces safer for women, leading to ventures like Wild City workshops and female-focused platforms such as the EQ Way.

"[Coven Code] also started doing other things aimed at improving the safety of women on the dance floor," says Grover, though their attempts at intervening in such situations often led to them getting harassed as well. "But then we created discrete threat-reporting mechanisms, pitched them to venues, started a hotline, even did bar staff sensitisation." Grover believes such initiatives were building momentum until the pandemic hit in 2020. Things have gotten worse since. As the music industry crawls back to life, footfalls and ticket sales have once again become the only guiding mantra for venues and promoters. Not only have safety and inclusivity taken a backseat, but problems like gender pay gap and the tokenisation of women as 'sexy DJs' have become more visible. "As a woman, it's always 'am I sexy enough to be a DJ?'" says Grover. "And that's so stupid. Why do I have to be sexy to be a DJ?" ■

Bhanuj Kappal



or deference to genre. From progressive house or techno to retro-style disco or Bollywood, she allows herself room to switch. In a way, her ability as an empath and her response to social settings perhaps direct her musical choices. "I was really into social anthropology, and the whole culture was very interesting to me. Even if I go to a dinner, or a *shaadi*, I feel the energy of the people," she says.

Lyla allows herself room to switch. She sidesteps any form of rigidity or deference to genre

Lyla moved to Karachi three years ago, into a vibrant club and electronic music culture. "But when I came, I noticed that there were only dudes on the dance floor." This prompted her to examine the reasons, and she felt that the music wasn't dynamic enough. And so, she set about incorporating some of the influences she'd picked up back in Glasgow. "I'd play boring house stuff, and sneak in a yesteryear disco song. People *like* lyrics sometimes, so I'd add music like that."

Her work landed her a slot on the first ever Boiler Room broadcast from Pakistan. Boiler Room is a prestigious broadcasting platform, popular across the world, and after being uploaded on YouTube in June, her set received over 500,000 views. She has since got calls to play gigs from all over, most prominently from India, though the logistics mean it's unlikely to happen. ■

Akhil Sood